

Cancel culture has no place at Laurentian

'Moral-grandstanding is built on sand. It will blow over'



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The Laurentian University campus in Sudbury, Ont. Colleagues write in a column that David Lesbarrères has been unfairly treated by the university.

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To lobby to damage the reputation, career, or family livelihood of people who disagree with you is not a particularly magnanimous instinct and mode of human behaviour. It is even less honourable when the person simply made a human error; worse still, if they felt deeply sorry and immediately apologized for the mistake, but the unforgiving mob still persisted in its cheap performative "justice".

President Obama has called this sort of thing “callout culture” or “cancel culture” ([nyti.ms/31Vx839](https://www.nytimes.com/2020/06/08/us/politics/cancel-culture.html)). People fall victim to it every day.

Most recently in Sudbury, it happened to David Lesbarrères, the French evolutionary ecologist and Dean of Graduate Studies at Laurentian University. We can all learn from his story. He is the canary in the coal mine.

On June 8, after having supported a black PhD student (bit.ly/2Ds0lHd) against prejudice, commenting on a thread about racial inequalities in a tweet that has since been deleted, Lesbarrères wrote:

“And shockingly enough on our campuses, even white males receive racist comments about their past. Why can’t we all see that we were once a monkey, let alone bacteria? #AllLivesMatters (sic).”

Admittedly, this was a quadruply clumsy tweet. Firstly, it was terribly timed. Now may not be the best moment to bring up anti-white racism. Secondly, it was poorly worded. We understand the rhetorical liberty taken to highlight our common evolutionary heritage in the spirit of anti-racism, but “monkey”? We can picture a belated facepalm. He may have misspelled Australopithecine.

The third microaggression is harder to catch without a PhD in Critical Race Studies. The general public may not know that many humanists today disbelieve in “anti-white racism”. There is no such thing, they say. It is labeled “reverse racism” and written off as a laughable oxymoron, a contradiction in terms like a married bachelor, Finnish verbosity, a Swedish coronavirus strategy, or a pothole-free Sudbury road. What Lesbarrères did was accidentally challenge this novel dogma.

But even that wasn’t what really killed him. He had accidentally stepped on a cultural landmine, which exploded in his face. It was the hashtag #AllLivesMatters, however curiously misspelled.

The following day, Lesbarrères posted two very apologetic tweets (bit.ly/3bmFFiO): “Last night, I issued a tweet that hurt many people. I apologize for my words and understand that I must educate myself further about #BlackLivesMatter and Tweeter (sic). I did not know that # (meaning #AllLivesMatter) existed and now realize it is rooted in values I do not hold and that I strongly condemn.” And: “I pledge to continue to educate myself, continue the fight for inclusivity and against racism, and I apologize to all people I have hurt.”

This heartfelt apology avoids all the mistakes of half-hearted faux apologies. No “I’m sorry, but” and no trace of “I’m sorry if it made you feel that way”. But not everyone was satisfied. How could he not have known the implications of that hashtag? We took him at his word: he did not know. Some academics are still too busy actually working to recognize every social media shibboleth. And so, they must be taught the hard way.

When there is genuine racism on campuses and communities that we proactively could and should be combatting together, to go after innocent scapegoats like this comes across as a diversion, a mockery of justice, and is painfully divisive.

If anything, we felt the apology was a tad excessive. We try to teach our children to apologise sincerely for honest mistakes – but not to grovel, especially if they are being pressured. When that happens, they should stand their ground. Why? Because what sensible people want is your apology, not subjugation. And insensible people will ultimately accept neither because what they want is blood under the guise of “deconstruction.”

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Before the thread discussing this controversy was taken down from the “UMentioned Laurentian” Facebook page, the most popular comments were by black, indigenous, and POC students who had initially been confused by Lesbarrères’s tweet but accepted his apology and presciently warned against turning this into a “witch hunt” (their words).

On Twitter, graduate student Bright Oppom Afum wrote: “Over the last 3.5 years, I’ve interacted with you as grad student, student leader and football opponent, I know the numerous interventions you’ve provided to international grad students. Let’s continue to make this world a better place” (bit.ly/3jKEm08).

Prior to Lesbarrères’s deanship, for example, international students were ineligible for academically valuable graduate teaching assistantships.

Professor of English Hoi Cheu’s wise words also merit repeating: “It is important not to make accusations because of the use of one sentence, which, in a different interpretative context, is not wrong. I worked with you to help many international students. I know you don’t hold the value behind ‘All lives matter’ in its current meaning” (bit.ly/31VIK6b).

But now we have learned that even if typed innocuously by an anti-racist professor with a long history of supporting

international students and other minorities, the hashtag will send you on an administrative leave for cultural “re-education” somewhere, we assume, in the Gulag. This is absolutely wrong and disgraceful.

To think that “black lives matter” means that white lives don’t matter is as silly and tone deaf as to think “all lives matter” means black lives don’t matter. For what it’s worth, although we spend more time on social media than is good for our mental health, even we did not realize until recently that “all lives matter” had been co-opted for racist purposes. At best, it was felt to dilute the message against anti-black racism. This is a fair concern.

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What message are we sending? Would you want to come work or study in a place that punishes you for a misconceived hashtag – a hashtag! – even if you publicly apologized for it? What message are we sending our students about making mistakes in life, about forgiveness and grace? We are setting them up to a life of fear, fragility, and pathological grievance by erecting these puritanical perfections that no-one can live up to. False perfection will kill us all. We must be better than this. We must be better than falsely perfect. We cannot decide whether this play is a farce or a tragedy. Whatever it is, it’s inhumane. And it makes us sad.

And so, we humbly implore our colleagues and friends who feel that they may have chastised Dr. Lesbarrères a little too hastily to please apologize to him. He is a person who evidently still takes apologies seriously, and will surely respond graciously.

And we urge colleagues and friends who have remained silent, perhaps in fear of personal and professional repercussions, to reach out to him. He must feel terrible and alone. Speak on his behalf – especially if you can speak from the privileged protection of tenure. You may have more to lose, but others are more likely to lose it. The problem with canary corpses, of course, is that they need to be replaced.

To employers, presidents, and board members everywhere, we say:

Stand by your falsely accused employees. Defend them publicly against online and on-campus purity mobs. Be the adult in the room. Do not cave in. The reputational loss or “impact” you fear is a conjured illusion. Moral-grandstanding is built on sand. It will blow over. Regardless of melanin levels, sexual orientations, and political leanings, the vast majority of students, faculty, staff, and other stakeholders – the vast majority of humanity – still recognize genuine virtue from cheap virtue-signaling, and will thank you for it.

Together, let’s call out this disgraceful and illiberal callout culture (and fix the damn roads). If we stopped being collective cowards, we could end it tomorrow. But if we do not muster our courage, we will lose also our remaining students to YouTube and Jordan Peterson. Come help bail the boat instead. The Academy is worth defending. We will need all hands on deck.

At Laurentian, that includes our colleague, Dr. Lesbarrères. We happily endorse the student-led petition [bit.ly/2QQiDaw] to have him reinstated as their dean. The Administration must undo the harm caused by tarnishing his character and reputation, and career.

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